



Playing the Periphery

A thesis submitted for the degree of
MA Games Design

by

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ABSTRACT

My topic of interest lies at the intersection of paratextual, corporeal, and sociocultural aspects of iconic game titles and their impact of their legacy. In other words, elements that lie at and/or outside the perimeter of the magic circle(Huizinga, 1949). Paratext consists of surrounding media not included in the game itself but strongly influencing how the experience is accessed, framed, and understood. Material comprises the physical means and contexts of play, in turn shaping the experience through sensory input, physical feedback, and presence. Community is embodied by the players themselves through shared habits, beliefs, and informal systems. The synergy of this trinity is flavoured by the aesthetics of the game playing experience in its entirety. Moreover, pairing any of these three permeates another facet of that external conceptual space.

In consideration of these angles, my project poses the following question:

In what ways can contemporary game design achieve holistic aesthetic experiences in the likeness of historically acclaimed game titles?

The research perspective is mostly aimed at context awareness and experiential revision, although, nostalgia remains a latent yet potent factor that bears investigation. Retrospective settings are being highlighted because most well-known titles from the past represent history as written by the victors.¹ With this in mind, I believe that game design can notably benefit from closely examining the external circumstances which frame any media product's release.

The theoretical research will examine existing frameworks established in game and media fields of study, intending to touch on fields and concepts such as experiential aesthetics, affect theory, procedural rhetoric, immersion, metagaming, preservation, and various design approaches. The practical review will survey an assortment of games whose play experience is notably characterised by contextual circumstances. This investigation is meant to derive patterns from exemplary case studies that can suggest ways of implanting the external layers of play experience into a new piece of playable media. With historical awareness providing the background, some of the findings will be incorporated into designing a digital artifact complementing the written one, accompanied by fictional context in the shape of lore and paraphernalia.

Comprehensive analysis of multiple real world scenarios is to be followed by a selection of applicable² approaches, which in turn will inform the directions taken throughout the design and development process. Concurrently, any relevant observations should be recorded with the intent to feed back into the writing and, eventually, provide a strong basis for reflection. Exercising theory in practice is expected to direct the unfolding of the game's design. The goal that I aspire to achieve with this project is tracing a model of media creation that is elevated by its surrounding context, and also aligns with key values established in my personal game design philosophy (GD5609, 2025), then put the resulting framework into future practice.

¹Or, in a few amusingly infamous cases, the kitschy underdogs and dark horses that are often both cautionary tales and subjects of cult following. Evidently, if one struggles to attain immortality via glory, becoming an anecdote remains a viable alternative.

²A word which here means (Snicket, 1999) "feasible".

CHAPTER 1 INTRODUCTION

Extrinsic Circles

Contextual influences and overall legacy impact are among the focal points for both primary and secondary sources considered in this paper. Theoretical examinations will mostly engage with the humanities of game studies - particularly sociocultural and media fields.

One sentence summary of written sources

However, the research question is more for the benefit of exploring an outside-in perspective on production and design, so it will be supported by practical use cases.

One sentence summary of gaming sources

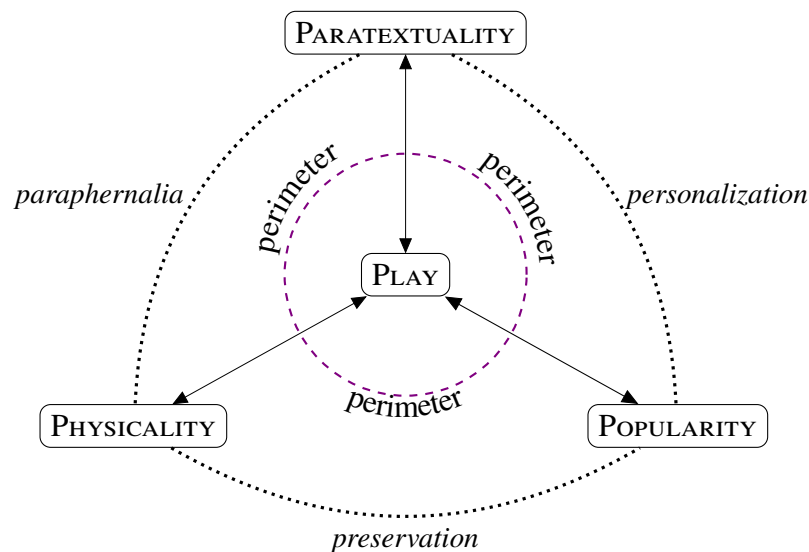


Figure 1.1: Peripheral aspects of play

When put together, Paratextuality, Physicality, and Popularity can be treated like X/Y/Z dimensional axes. Given any game as a source, evaluating its properties as measures along these axes yields coordinates that denote the facets of paraphernalia, preservation, and personalisation.

Premise

I have made the possibly unconventional choice of splitting the practical half of this project further into two games. One has the digital prototype role, while the other is rather a conceptual case study. The reason for that approach is a matter of positioning. In order to focus on analysing the outer spaces of gameplay experience, it is almost imperative that the foundation itself is built *outside* said gameplay, with the design & creation process directed *inwards*. Keeping in mind the immutable reality of human limitations, a retrospective inquiry at the aesthetic legacy and sociocultural impact of a video game developed by a solo student, on a scale large enough to be of any consequence, is not only an infeasible undertaking, but one that would naturally steer all efforts towards actual development at the expense of design. Although that would be an achievement of large proportions, it would bring little value towards the purpose of this exercise. As it turns out, the subject of the case study does not, technically, exist. At least not in the form of the playable media it is supposed to represent. Rather, it shall be defined through negative space, i.e., the silhouette made from all the shapes that are not intrinsic to its architecture. Design will largely be catered by the lost game, while implementation will be relegated to the mini game. The latter has the role of an interactive loading screen, serving as waiting distraction that provides some preparatory advice for the former. Detailed overviews for both game layers can be found in Chapter 4 and Appendix A.

CHAPTER 2 LITERATURE REVIEW

Paratextualizing Games (2021)

Metagames

2.1 Paratextuality

The initial concept by Gérard Genette (1997) has been considerably expanded to better fit the field of game studies, and as a result has been entangled with adjacent terms from the original scholar's typology.¹ However, both approaches can be integrated into my own, owing to the generous overlap between the three types of external context.

When strictly categorising cases, Genette's definition regards "Elements that form a figurative threshold of a text and ground it in a socio-historical context. [...] must be created by the text's producers or their associates". These can be promotional materials, introductory sequences, menus, credits, making-ofs, contextual information about authors.

While preserving Genette's wording on which elements are included, Consalvo's interpretation assigns "...no limitations on authorship or cultural status" (2007). This is akin to *cultural epiphenomena* and allows consideration of more media like "criticism and journalism, user discussions, fan fiction and fan art, streaming, trans-media storytelling" (Švelch, 2020).

On these grounds, Genette's delineation is the more clear and straightforward directive for labelling purposes, while Consalvo's expansion on it draws a connection to cultural assimilation. Additionally, both have ties to materiality in their manifestation.

2.2 Physicality

proper lit review of physicality

The most tangible of the three aspects, this refers to all the material conditions in which the game is played. Exclusively, this covers authentic hardware and peripherals, physical data storage, haptic features, and environmental settings. In addition, paratextual supplements in physical format, e.g., paper, fall under the same category to form paraphernalia.

2.3 Popularity

proper lit review on popularity

¹The five aspects of *transtextuality* comprise of: *inter-*, *meta-*, *hyper-*, *archi-*, and *para-*texts.

Culture and society permeate the first two aspects via informal systems of shared habits, beliefs and conventions. The formation of social rituals by the demographic over time leads to emergent paratext, stemming from reception and circulation, and physical aspects are embodied in player presence and direct interaction with the hardware.

CHAPTER 3 CASE STUDIES

CASE: “UFO50”

CASE: “Inscription”

CASE: Feelies

CASE: Swordquest

CASE: “StarTropics”

CASE: “The Vectrex Arcade System”

Apply P-framework

Support
with sec-
ondary
sources

CHAPTER 4 DESIGN & DEVELOPMENT

4.1 The Lost AMOLED

Clever Rebel Trials was an ambitious attempt to reinvent platform exclusivity following the 4th Generation's Console Wars. Rather than developing a killer app for a designated system, Adelin Melony (1970-2002) set out to create a machine whose sole purpose was to play the one game that it was optimised for. The game itself was released in 1997 on the Ludic Entertainment Device - its dedicated Generation 4.5 console that was soon dubbed "Addie Mel's One-Shot LED", shortened to AMOLED. While the approach is not unheard of (being a standard practice for arcade cabinets and many 1st and 2nd generation products) such an idea carries major risks concerning scope, audience demand and reception.

CRT is set in a retro-futuristic world with competing factions offering exclusive membership perks. The main gameplay loop revolves around managing a multitude of characters from the Clever Rebels Team. Each rebel specialises in a very narrow field of studies, which makes for entirely different character builds and run strategies.

Notes from the GM The creator's names are anagrams using the first names of Daniel Handler, whom she also shares a birthday with, and his pseudonym Lemony Snicket. Chronologically, her lifetime closely matches the birth and growth of videogame technology, but was sadly cut short when she was only 32 years old.

Although they have been swapped and scrambled into vague equivalents, most names within this alternate universe originate from the ASOUE books (Snicket, 1999).

In them, there are also mentions of a secret organisation called VFD. In Snicket's world VFD stands for Volunteer Fire Department, but in ours, among other things, it means Vacuum Fluorescent Display. I found the notion of using other display type acronyms amusing, hence CRT and LED/AMOLED.

Beside having a name reminiscent of NES, the LED console with its CRT game came out at a time of a literal dimensional shift in computer graphics technology - a transition from 16-bit pixels on cartridges to 32-bit polygons on optical discs with all the new rendering and memory management methodologies it brought about. ¹

4.2 The Peripheral Potpourri

¹It also may or may not conveniently share a birthyear with yours truly.

Primary sources for direction on skill progression: Final Fantasy jobs and Children of Morta

Paraphernalia

Paratextuality + Physicality

Which manuals informed the design of mine in terms of gameplay and hardware notes

Preservation

Physicality + Popularity

What has survived, in what format, and why?

Hardware quirks: dials, 2 screens?

Primary sources for direction on odd hardware: Magnavox Odyssey, Vectrex, Playdate, DnD?

Personalisation

Paratextuality + Popularity

The role of discussions on interpretations and practices in shaping legacy

4.3 The Salvaged Software

Why does it exist? Platform and player calibration - check controls while getting acclimatised

Prototype

wireframe with legit software



Figure 4.1: “Paper” prototype

Primary sources for direction: Space Invaders loading mini-game and The Sims cases

Layout & UI devnotes

Environment devnotes

opening screen

tree growth stages

fully grown trees → saplings

forest coverage → cloud size

cloud size → raindrops amount

correct car controls

auto-pilot fire-truck

upgradable bucket

auto-collecting bucket

score → loading progress → full bar → start button to end game

Vleugels, 2021; Schostok, 2007; Art-Michel, 2025

ASSETS
HUNT-
ING: back-
ground?,
cursor?,
loading
bar, steer-
ing wheel,
sounds and
animation

CHAPTER 5 SYNTHESIS

Theory in practice: how they informed and/or clashed with each other

Revision of the artifact(s)

Correlation with sources?

Provisional answer to the research question.

CHAPTER 6 CONCLUSION

Critical reflection on achievement

Outline of implications and further research directions to build upon.

Recommended reading/playing not mentioned in earlier chapters

Final word count minus references, footnotes and appendices

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APPENDIX A

PARATEXTS

A.1 Manual

Lay out layout

Setting and Campaigns

Key factions and events; Known unknowns;

Characters' Progression & Skill trees

Hardware notes

A.2 Articles

A.2.1 Magazine preview

Write promo content

A.2.2 Webpage review

Scaffold HTML page

Write critical content

A.3 Message board(s)

Finish up webpage

fill thread with user comments

TO-DO List

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